

COMPLETE CHESS LEARNING LIBRARY

The Complete Gruenfeld Defense

Attack the center with pieces, theory families, and dynamic counterplay

COURSE BOOK

20 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

How to Use This Course

ONE CHAPTER, FOUR PASSES

1. Read the position without moving pieces. 2. State your plan and the opponent's counterplay. 3. Study the decision rules. 4. Close the book and reconstruct the position from memory.

RETRIEVAL SCHEDULE

Review the chapter the next day, one week later, and after a game that reaches a similar structure. Retrieval is more valuable than rereading.

BOARD ROUTINE

Opponent's threat - forcing moves - loose pieces - worst piece - central break - best reply - choose and stop.

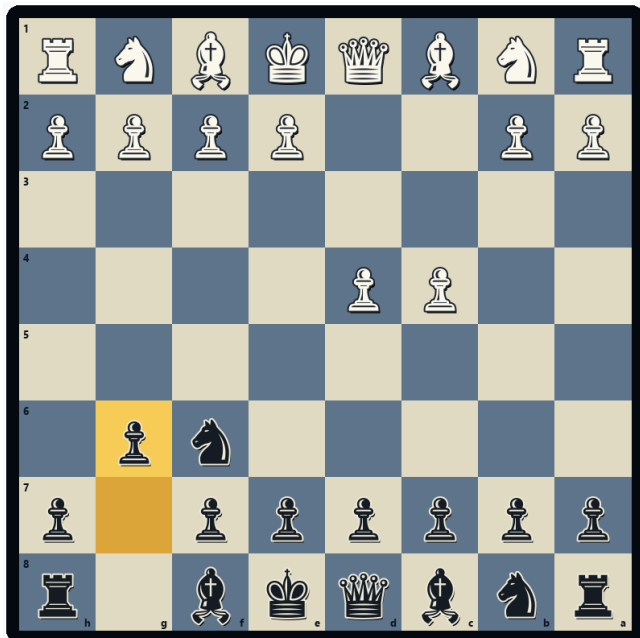
The course book explains each model position. The separate workbook forces recall, prediction, and self-scoring. Use the book first, then attempt the matching workbook page without looking back.

Engine evaluations are intentionally not the lesson. The aim is to store human decision rules that remain useful when the exact move order changes.

Course Map

MODULE	CHAPTERS
01 - Foundation	2
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01. Gruenfeld Core - Move Order



01 - Foundation

READ THE POSITION

Reach the Gruenfeld Core structure without giving the opponent a free tactical or central improvement.

PRIMARY PLAN

Complete the essential development, identify the central commitment, and preserve the option that makes the full position useful.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White builds e4 and tries to turn the center into lasting space.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6

MEMORY RULE

Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Gruenfeld Core.

01. Decision Framework

Gruenfeld Core - Move Order

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

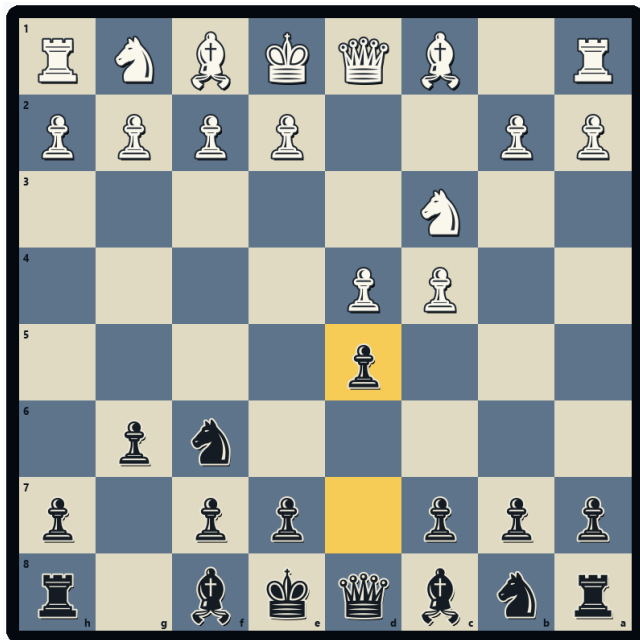
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Gruenfeld Core.

02. Gruenfeld Core



01 - Foundation

READ THE POSITION

Black allows White a broad center and attacks it with pieces and pawn breaks.

PRIMARY PLAN

Pressure d4, use ...c5, and value activity over static space.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White builds e4 and tries to turn the center into lasting space.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 d5

MEMORY RULE

The Gruenfeld invites the center so it can become a target.

02. Decision Framework

Gruenfeld Core

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

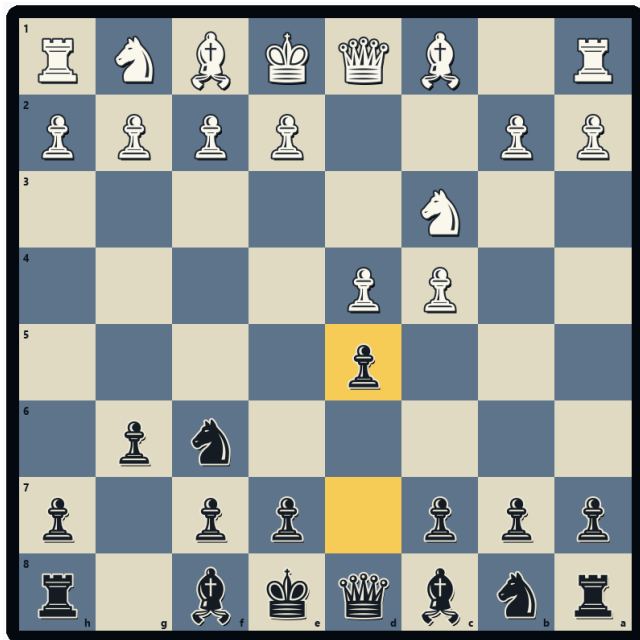
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: The Gruenfeld invites the center so it can become a target.

03. Exchange Variation - Move Order



02 - Exchange

READ THE POSITION

Reach the Exchange Variation structure without giving the opponent a free tactical or central improvement.

PRIMARY PLAN

Complete the essential development, identify the central commitment, and preserve the option that makes the full position useful.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White develops Be3, Qd2, and active rooks behind the center.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 d5

MEMORY RULE

Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Exchange Variation.

03. Decision Framework

Exchange Variation - Move Order

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

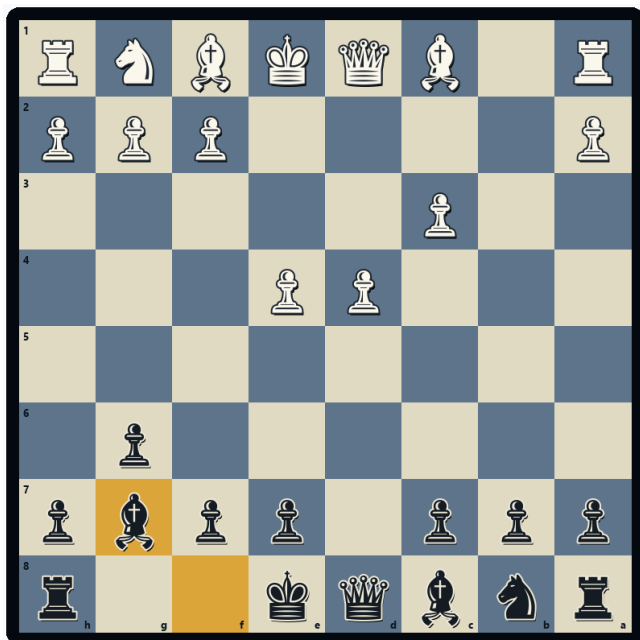
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Exchange Variation.

04. Exchange Variation



02 - Exchange

READ THE POSITION

White gains the classical center while Black removes a defender and attacks d4.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use ...c5, the long diagonal, and pressure on d4 before White consolidates.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White develops Be3, Qd2, and active rooks behind the center.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 d5 4. cxd5 Nxd5 5. e4 Nxc3 6. bxc3 Bg7

MEMORY RULE

Attack the center's base before its space advantage becomes permanent.

04. Decision Framework

Exchange Variation

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
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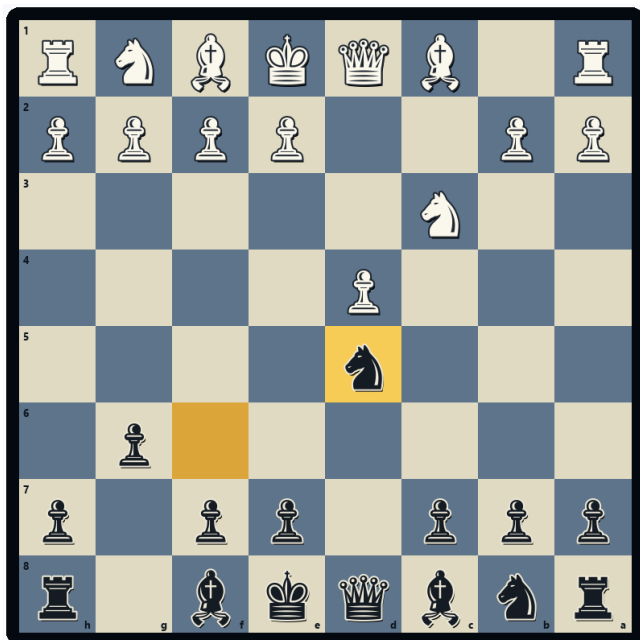
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Attack the center's base before its space advantage becomes permanent.

05. Exchange Main Line - Move Order



02 - Exchange

READ THE POSITION

Reach the Exchange Main Line structure without giving the opponent a free tactical or central improvement.

PRIMARY PLAN

Complete the essential development, identify the central commitment, and preserve the option that makes the full position useful.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White supports d4 and may advance d5 when Black's pieces lose contact.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 d5 4. cxd5 Nxd5

MEMORY RULE

Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Exchange Main Line.

05. Decision Framework

Exchange Main Line - Move Order

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
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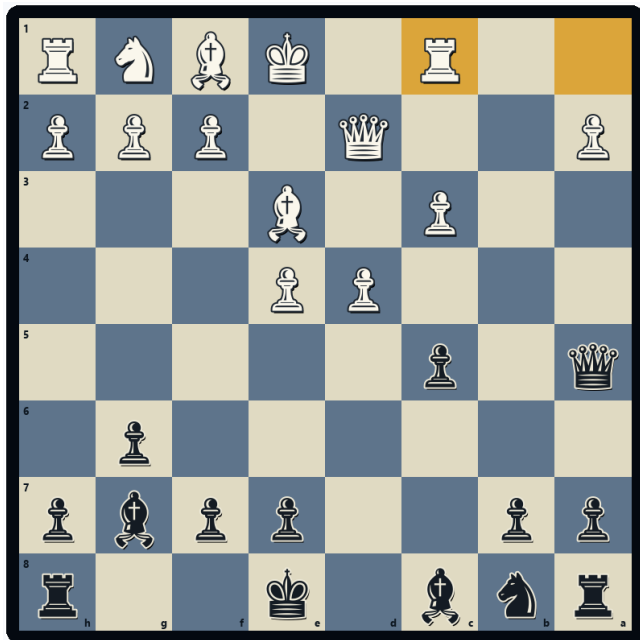
ACTIVE RECALL

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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Exchange Main Line.

06. Exchange Main Line



02 - Exchange

READ THE POSITION

Both sides coordinate around d4 and the long diagonal.

PRIMARY PLAN

Increase pressure without neglecting development or king safety.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White supports d4 and may advance d5 when Black's pieces lose contact.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 d5 4. cxd5 Nxd5 5. e4 Nxc3 6. bxc3 Bg7 7. Be3 c5 8. Qd2 Qa5 9. Rc1

MEMORY RULE

The center advances when pressure disappears; keep enough attackers on d4.

06. Decision Framework

Exchange Main Line

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
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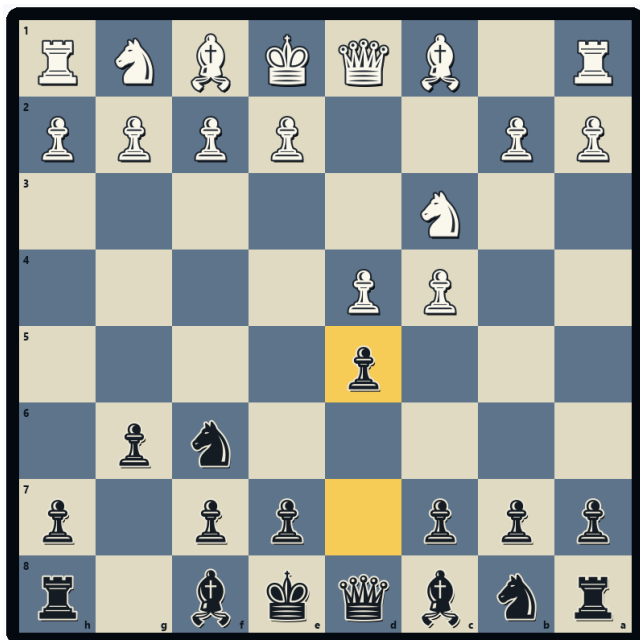
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3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: The center advances when pressure disappears; keep enough attackers on d4.

07. Russian System - Move Order



03 - Russian

READ THE POSITION

Reach the Russian System structure without giving the opponent a free tactical or central improvement.

PRIMARY PLAN

Complete the essential development, identify the central commitment, and preserve the option that makes the full position useful.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White uses the broad center and active queen to gain space.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 d5

MEMORY RULE

Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Russian System.

07. Decision Framework

Russian System - Move Order

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

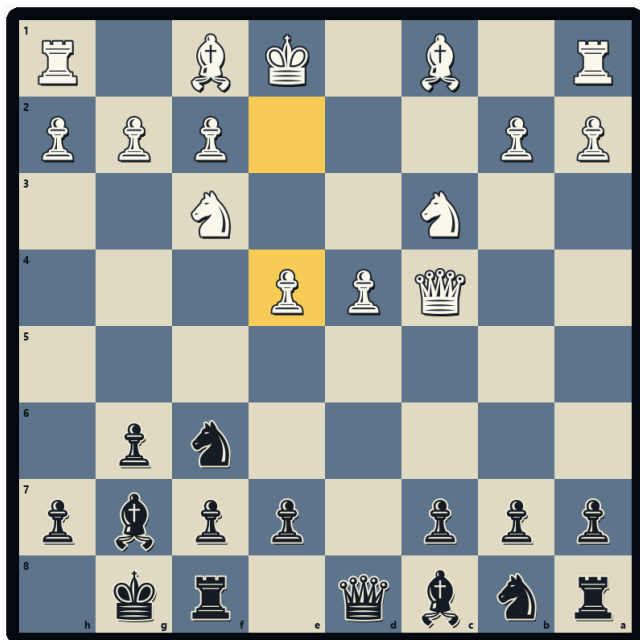
ACTIVE RECALL

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3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Russian System.

08. Russian System



03 - Russian

READ THE POSITION

White builds e4 while using the queen to recover c4.

PRIMARY PLAN

Develop with tempo against the queen and strike with ...c5.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White uses the broad center and active queen to gain space.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 d5 4. Nf3 Bg7 5. Qb3 dxc4 6. Qxc4 O-O 7. e4

MEMORY RULE

The Russian System gives White a center but gives Black targets and tempi.

08. Decision Framework

Russian System

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
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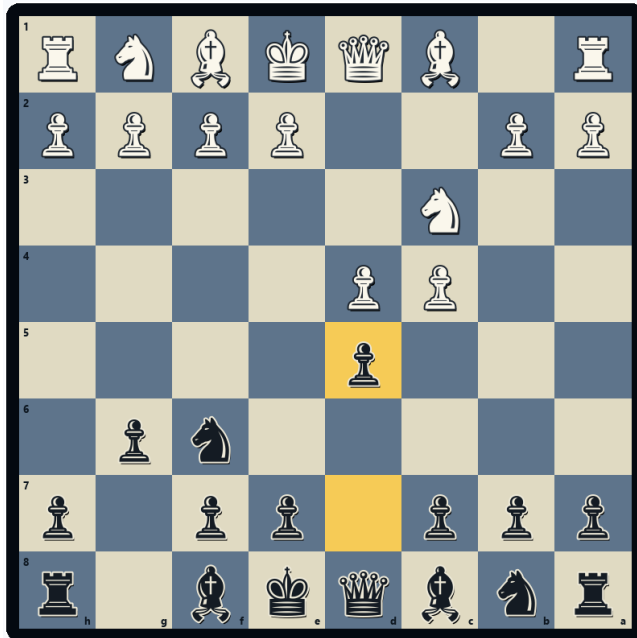
ACTIVE RECALL

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3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: The Russian System gives White a center but gives Black targets and tempi.

09. Fianchetto Gruenfeld - Move Order



04 - Fianchetto

READ THE POSITION

Reach the Fianchetto Gruenfeld structure without giving the opponent a free tactical or central improvement.

PRIMARY PLAN

Complete the essential development, identify the central commitment, and preserve the option that makes the full position useful.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White recovers the pawn and uses the long diagonal with stable development.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 d5

MEMORY RULE

Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Fianchetto Gruenfeld.

09. Decision Framework

Fianchetto Gruenfeld - Move Order

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

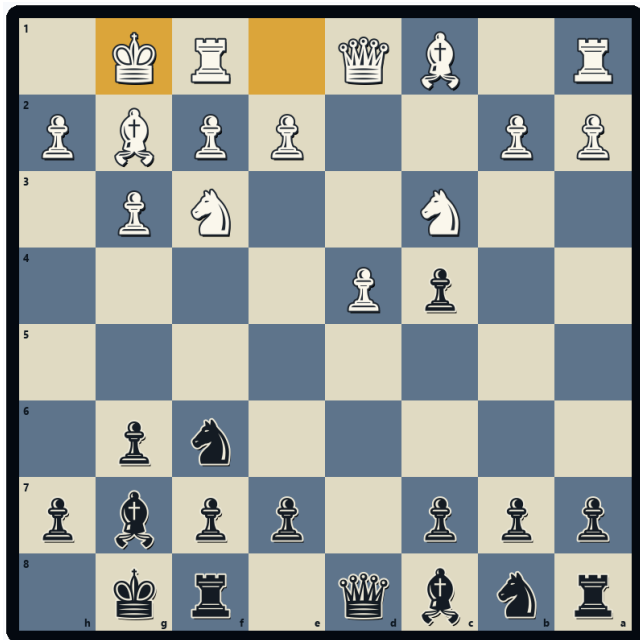
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Fianchetto Gruenfeld.

10. Fianchetto Gruenfeld



04 - Fianchetto

READ THE POSITION

White mirrors the bishop and accepts an open Catalan-like structure.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use ...c5 and queenside activity before White recovers c4 comfortably.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White recovers the pawn and uses the long diagonal with stable development.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 d5 4. Nf3 Bg7 5. g3 O-O 6. Bg2 dxc4 7. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Against the fianchetto, activity must justify releasing the center.

10. Decision Framework

Fianchetto Gruenfeld

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
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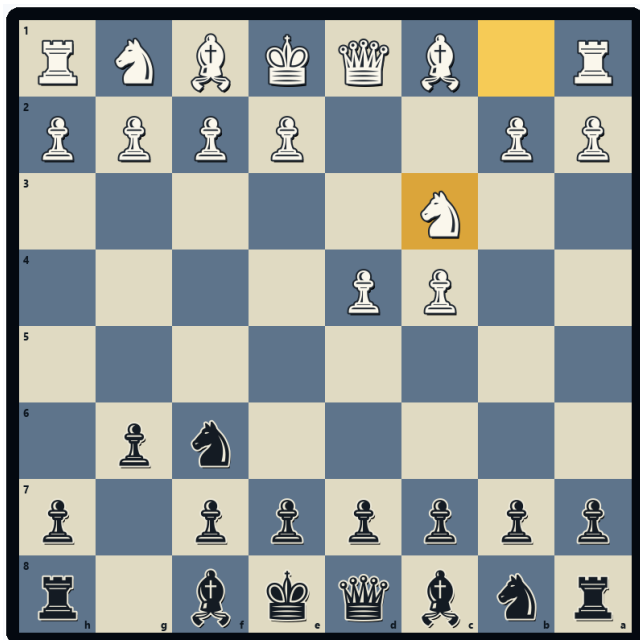
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Against the fianchetto, activity must justify releasing the center.

11. 4.Bf4 System - Move Order



05 - Bf4 and Bg5

READ THE POSITION

Reach the 4.Bf4 System structure without giving the opponent a free tactical or central improvement.

PRIMARY PLAN

Complete the essential development, identify the central commitment, and preserve the option that makes the full position useful.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White uses Nf3, Rc1, and central stability.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3

MEMORY RULE

Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward 4.Bf4 System.

11. Decision Framework

4.Bf4 System - Move Order

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

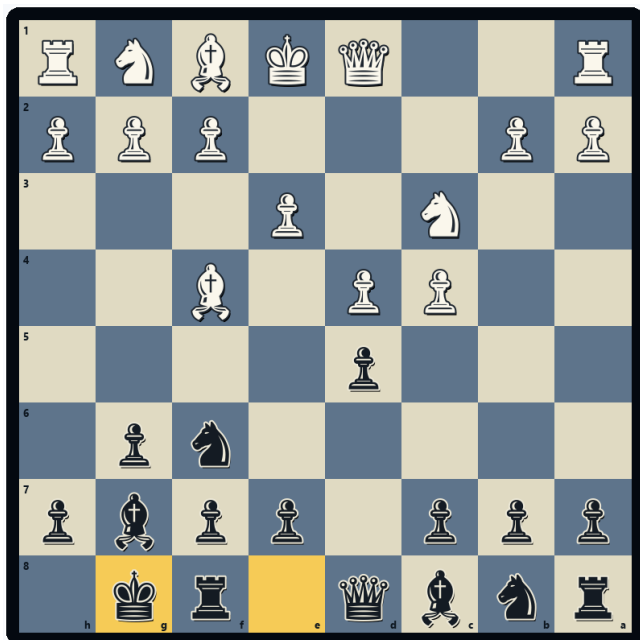
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward 4.Bf4 System.

12. 4.Bf4 System



05 - Bf4 and Bg5

READ THE POSITION

White develops actively and supports e3 without committing the knight.

PRIMARY PLAN

Challenge d4 with ...c5 and watch queenside development.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White uses Nf3, Rc1, and central stability.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 d5 4. Bf4 Bg7 5. e3 O-O

MEMORY RULE

When White develops smoothly, Black's pawn break must arrive on time.

12. Decision Framework

4.Bf4 System

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

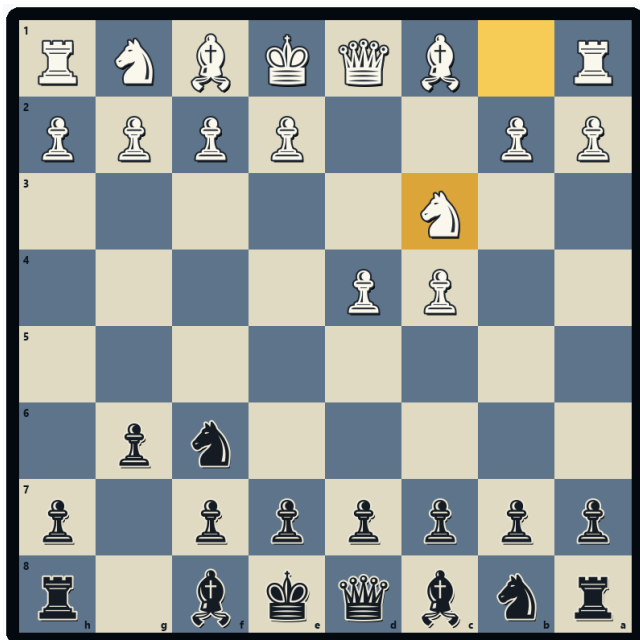
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: When White develops smoothly, Black's pawn break must arrive on time.

13. 4.Bg5 System - Move Order



05 - Bf4 and Bg5

READ THE POSITION

Reach the 4.Bg5 System structure without giving the opponent a free tactical or central improvement.

PRIMARY PLAN

Complete the essential development, identify the central commitment, and preserve the option that makes the full position useful.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White gains the bishop pair and central pawns.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3

MEMORY RULE

Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward 4.Bg5 System.

13. Decision Framework

4.Bg5 System - Move Order

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

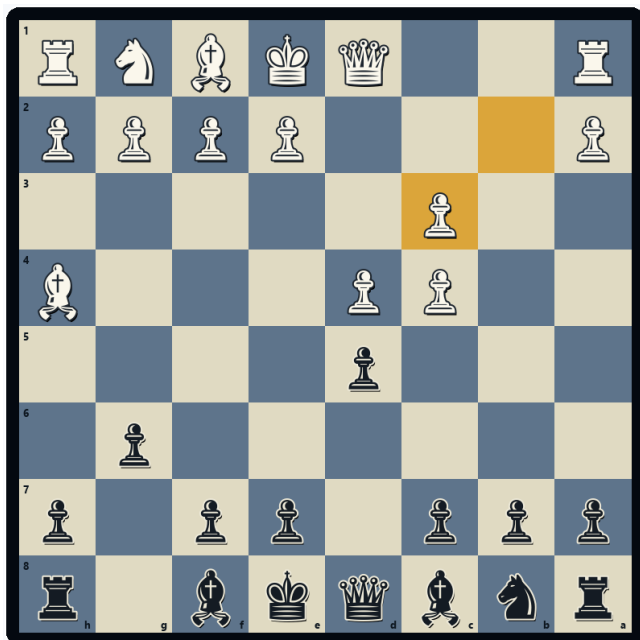
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward 4.Bg5 System.

14. 4.Bg5 System



05 - Bf4 and Bg5

READ THE POSITION

Black attacks the bishop and changes White's structure by exchanging on c3.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use the structural change and long diagonal to challenge the center.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White gains the bishop pair and central pawns.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 d5 4. Bg5 Ne4 5. Bh4 Nxc3 6. bxc3

MEMORY RULE

A structural concession is acceptable when it improves pressure and activity.

14. Decision Framework

4.Bg5 System

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: A structural concession is acceptable when it improves pressure and activity.

15. 3.f3 Gruenfeld - Move Order



06 - f3 Systems

READ THE POSITION

Reach the 3.f3 Gruenfeld structure without giving the opponent a free tactical or central improvement.

PRIMARY PLAN

Complete the essential development, identify the central commitment, and preserve the option that makes the full position useful.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White accepts development risk for a broad pawn center.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3

MEMORY RULE

Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward 3.f3 Gruenfeld.

15. Decision Framework

3.f3 Gruenfeld - Move Order

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

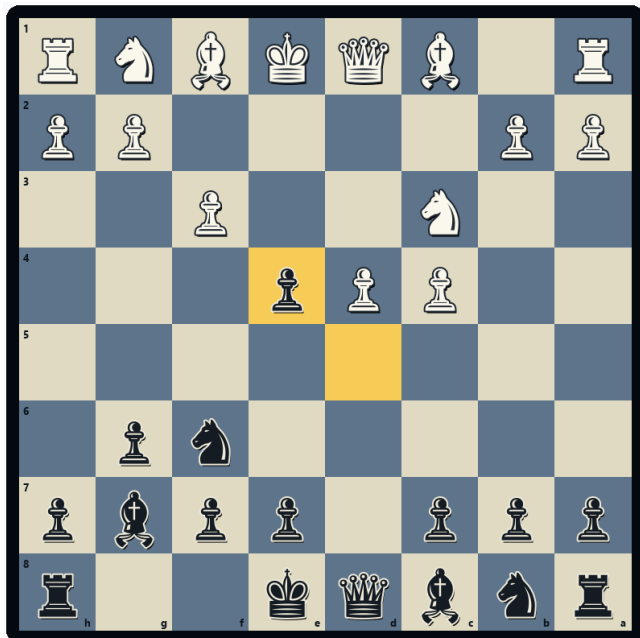
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward 3.f3 Gruenfeld.

16. 3.f3 Gruenfeld



06 - f3 Systems

READ THE POSITION

White builds an immediate e4 center and delays development.

PRIMARY PLAN

Open the center before White secures the king and coordinate pressure on d4.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White accepts development risk for a broad pawn center.

REFERENCE LINE 1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 d5 4. f3 Bg7 5. e4 dxe4

MEMORY RULE

Against f3, attack the center before the king finds safety.

16. Decision Framework

3.f3 Gruenfeld

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

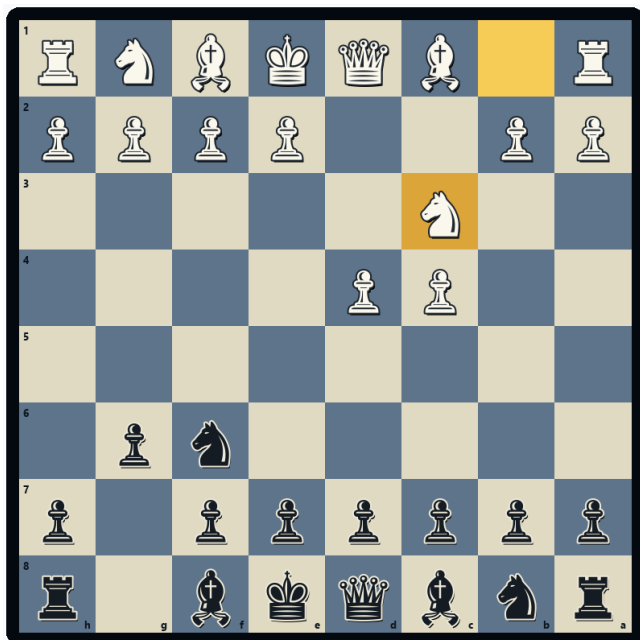
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Against f3, attack the center before the king finds safety.

17. 5.Na4 - Move Order



07 - Sidelines

READ THE POSITION

Reach the 5.Na4 structure without giving the opponent a free tactical or central improvement.

PRIMARY PLAN

Complete the essential development, identify the central commitment, and preserve the option that makes the full position useful.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White seeks e4 without doubled pawns.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3

MEMORY RULE

Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward 5.Na4.

17. Decision Framework

5.Na4 - Move Order

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

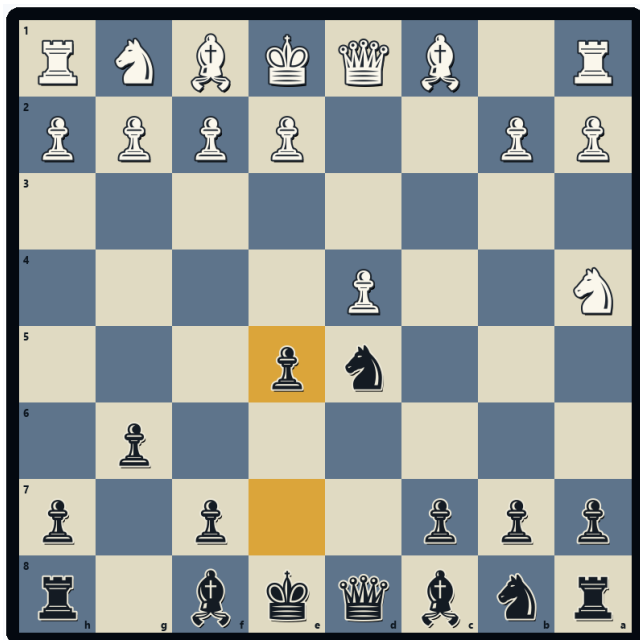
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward 5.Na4.

18. 5.Na4



07 - Sidelines

READ THE POSITION

White avoids the structural exchange and questions the d5-knight.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use ...e5 and active development to justify the centralized knight.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White seeks e4 without doubled pawns.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 d5 4. cxd5 Nxd5 5. Na4 e5

MEMORY RULE

Sideways knight moves cost time; answer with central activity.

18. Decision Framework

5.Na4

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

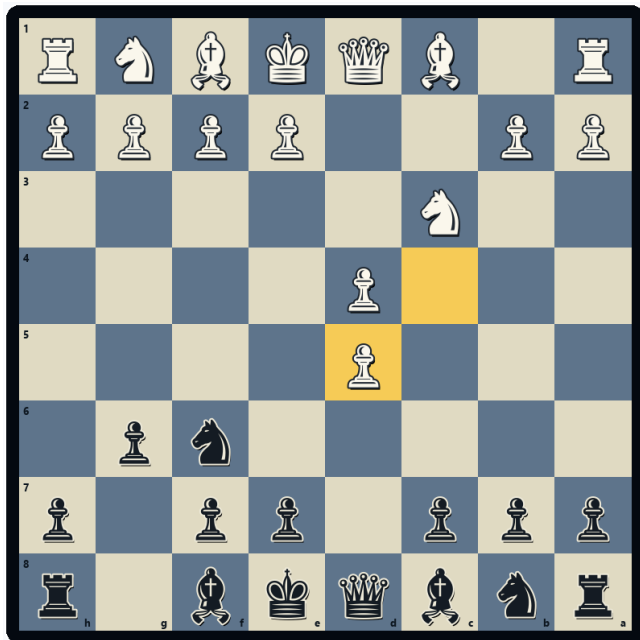
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Sideways knight moves cost time; answer with central activity.

19. Exchange with Bc4 - Move Order



02 - Exchange

READ THE POSITION

Reach the Exchange with Bc4 structure without giving the opponent a free tactical or central improvement.

PRIMARY PLAN

Complete the essential development, identify the central commitment, and preserve the option that makes the full position useful.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White uses the center and direct development for initiative.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 d5 4. cxd5

MEMORY RULE

Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Exchange with Bc4.

19. Decision Framework

Exchange with Bc4 - Move Order

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

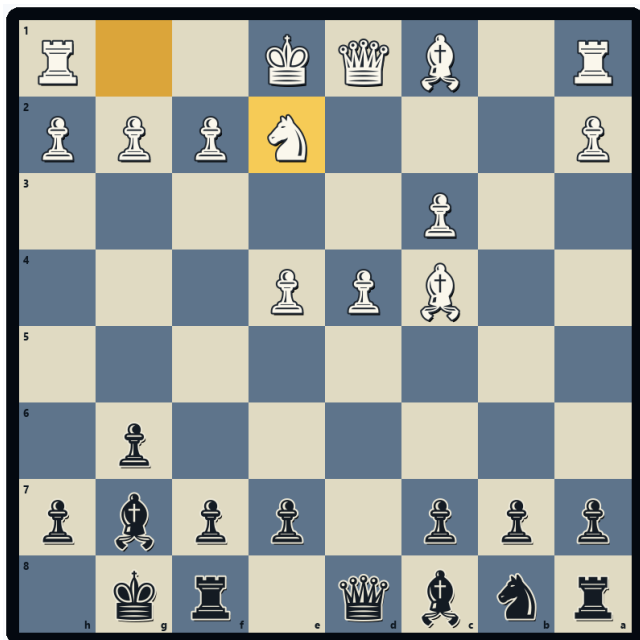
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Move-order rule: know what changes before steering toward Exchange with Bc4.

20. Exchange with Bc4



02 - Exchange

READ THE POSITION

White develops the bishop actively and prepares rapid castling.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use ...c5 and pressure before White completes coordination.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White uses the center and direct development for initiative.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 d5 4. cxd5 Nxd5 5. e4 Nxc3 6. bxc3 Bg7 7. Bc4 O-O 8. Ne2

MEMORY RULE

In open Gruenfeld positions, every tempo toward the center matters.

20. Decision Framework

Exchange with Bc4

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Before committing, check forcing replies, loose pieces, tactical pins, and the opponent's strongest central resource.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: In open Gruenfeld positions, every tempo toward the center matters.

Course Completion Test

Choose ten chapters at random. Rebuild each reference position, name both sides' plans, identify the critical break, and state the trade filter without reopening the chapter.

Score one point for the structure, one for your plan, one for counterplay, one for the break, and one for the memory rule. Forty out of fifty means the knowledge is usable; below forty means retrieval practice should continue.

FINAL PRINCIPLE

A course is complete when its ideas appear in your decisions, not when its pages have been read.